

Single ID card for multi-purpose usage

The Unique Identification Authority of India (UIDAI) is a government of India agency, responsible for implementing *Aadhaar*—a unique identification project in India. It was set up in 2009, and will operate the unique identification number database. The authority would provide a unique number to all Indians, but not the smart cards. The authority would provide a database of residents containing very simple data in biometrics.

A smart card-based national ID offers a simple mechanism for unique and secure identification of each citizen. Coupled with biometric data, it can provide a standalone authentication of the card holder, or authentication through a central database, depending on the application needs. This smart card can be used to authenticate for several purposes without the need for multiple documentations or repeated applications for individual services.

Gujarat and Madhya Pradesh have already adopted it and others are yet to follow. "Till now about eight states have started issuing DL/RC on smart cards. As per my understanding, the minimum number of smart cards to be issued in each state would be not less than 10 million on an average. Hence, the requirement for smart cards in this sector is extremely high," opines Anil Agarwal, director, ID Smart Cards Creations. The company is not only into designing, developing and producing smart cards but also manufactures smart card machines.

Besides, security requirements in the country would lead to government initiatives for smart card-based national ID cards and e-passports. The unique identity (UID) is another application area that is expected to become the backbone for all such government initiatives.

Growth of smart card market and the propellers

As governments in a violence-ripped world fall back on technology for security, smart cards are poised to drive the next sunrise industry, globally. The Indian smart card market is also set to move upward, with UIDAI being the main propeller. Furthermore, booming economy and strong demand for digital security is leading to the demand for smart cards. "With the smart card market expected to grow from the current base of 40 million cards to 600 million cards in the next few years, both Indian as well as foreign smart card companies are showing keen interest in this market," states Abishek Lakhotia,

manager, business development, ID Tech Solutions, a leading smart card manufacturer.

Though the smart card market in India is still at a nascent stage, major smart cards players see immense potential in it. It is expected that 600 million unique ID cards, 50 million e-passports, 100 million health cards, 50 million transport and ticketing cards and 50 million banking cards will be issued over the next seven years in India. Furthermore, the Central and various state governments are launching initiatives creating ample space for this multi-purpose ID card.

"With large consumer base and huge untapped potential, India offers immense opportunities to smart card players. The smart card industry has been continuously expanding, with states across the country identifying its true potential. The number of smart card application projects has also been rising, demonstrating the versatility and robustness of the technology. The growing security needs, possible multiple usage (*Aadhaar*) and greater storage and processing capability are driving the growth of smart card industry," says Sudhakar N.

The telecom market, banking as well as biometrics are other sectors demanding smart card solutions. There are other applications such as healthcare, university and electronic access control systems (EACs) that are gaining acceptance in the country. Currently, the telecom sector uses the highest number of smart cards in the form of SIM cards as the penetration of mobile phones is increasing in In-

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